AMCULUM

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Amethyſtine / Amianthus

gular, ſemiquinquefid, and perſiſtent: The *corolla* is monopetalous; the border quinquepartite, the loweſt diviſion more expanding: The *ſtamina* conſiſt of two ſlender filaments approximated; the antheræ are ſimple and roundiſh: The *piſtillum* has a four-cleft germen; ſtylus, the ſize of the ſtamina; ſtigmata two, acute: No *corolla*: The *ſeeds* four, gibbous, and ſhorter than the calyx:—There is only one known ſpecies.

This plant is a native of Siberia, from whence the ſeeds were ſent to the imperial garden at Peterſburgh, and thence brought to Britain. It is an annual plant, with an upright ſtalk, which riſes about a foot high. Towards the top it puts forth two or three ſmall lateral branches, garniſhed with ſmall trifid leaves, ſawed on their edges, of a very dark green colour. The flowers appear in June or July, and are produced in ſmall umbels at the extremities of the branches. They are of a fine blue colour, as are alſo the upper part of the branches, and the leaves immediately under the umbel, ſo that they make a fine appearance.

Culture. The ſeeds of the amethyſtea ſhould be ſown in autumn, as they are apt to remain a whole year in the ground if kept till the ſpring. When the plants come up, nothing elſe is neceſſary than to keep them clear of weeds, and to thin them where they are too cloſe. They ought to be ſown where they are to remain, as they do not thrive when tranſplanted.

AMETHYSTINE is applied, in antiquity, to a kind of purple garment dyed of the hue of amethyſt. In this ſenſe amethyſtine differed from *Tyrian* as well as from *hyacinthine* purple, being a kind of medium between both.

AMHAR, or Amhara, a province of Abyſſinia, ſaid to extend 40 leagues from eaſt to weſt. It is conſidered as the moſt noble in the whole empire, both on account of its being the uſual reſidence of the Abyſſinian monarchs, and having a particular dialect different from all the reſt, which, by reaſon of the emperors being brought up in this province, is become the language of the court and of the politer people. Here is the famed rock Amba-geſhen, where the young monarchs were formerly confined. See Amba.

AMHURST (Nicholas), an Engliſh poet and political writer, was born at Marden in Kent, and entered of St John's college, Oxford; from whence he was expelled for irregularity of conduct and libertine principles. Retaining great reſentment againſt the univerſity on this account, he abuſed its learning and diſcipline, and ſome of the moſt reſpectable characters in it, in a poem publiſhed in 1724 called *Oculus Britanniæ*, and in a book intitled *Terræ Filius*. He publiſhed, a Miſcellany of Poems, ſacred and profane; and, The Convocation, a poem in five cantos, which was a ſatire on the Biſhop of Bangor's antagoniſts. But he is beſt known for the ſhare he had in the political paper called *The Craftſman*: though, after having been the drudge of his party for near 20 years, he was as much forgot in the famous compromiſe of 1742 as if he had never been born; and, when he died in that year of a broken heart, was indebted to the charity of his bookſeller for a grave.

AMIANTHUS, or Earth-flax, in natural hiſtory, a fibrous, flexile, elaſtic, mineral ſubſtance, conſiſting of ſhort, abrupt, and interwoven filaments. It is found in Germany, in the ſtrata of iron ore, ſometimes forming veins of an inch in diameter. Its fibres are ſo flexible that cloth has been made of them, and the ſhorter filaments that ſeparate in the waſhing of the ſtone may be made into paper in the common manner. For the method of its preparation for manufacture into cloth, ſee Asbestos. Amicable / Amida.

Amianthus is claſſed by Mr Kirwan in the muriatic genus of earths, becauſe it contains about a fifth part of magneſia. Its other conſtituents are, flint, mild calcareous earth, barytes, clay, and a very ſmall proportion of iron. It is fuſible *per ſe* in a ſtrong heat, and alſo with the common fluxes. It differs from aſbeſtos in containing ſome ponderous earth.

AMICABLE, in a general ſenſe, denotes any thing done in a friendly manner, or to promote peace.

Amicable Benches, in Roman antiquity, were, according to Pitiſcus, lower and leſs honourable ſeats allotted for the *judices pedanei*, or inferior judges, who, upon being admitted of the emperor's council, were dignified by him with the title *amici*.

Amicable Numbers, ſuch as are mutually equal to the ſum of one another's aliquot parts. Thus the numbers 284 and 220 are amicable numbers: for the aliquot parts 1, 2, 4, 5, 10, 11, 20, 22, 44, 55, 110, of 220, are together equal to the other number 284; and the aliquot parts 1, 2, 4, 71, 142, of 284, are together equal to 220.

AMICTUS, in Roman antiquity, was any upper garment worn over the tunica.

Amictus, among eccleſiaſtical writers, the uppermoſt garment anciently worn by the clergy; the other five being the alba, ſingulum, ſtola, manipulus, and planeta. The amictus was a linen garment, of a ſquare figure, covering the head, neck, and ſhoulders, and buckled or claſped before the breaſt. It is ſtill worn by the religious abroad.

AMICULUM, in Roman antiquity, a woman's upper garment, which differed from the pala. It was worn both by matrons and courtezans.

Amicus curiæ, a Law term, to denote a by-ſtander who informs the court of a matter in law that is doubtful or miſtaken.

AMIDA, a god worſhipped by the Japaneſe, who has many temples erected to him in the iſland of Japan, of which the principal is at Jedo. The Japaneſe have ſuch a confidence in their idol Amida, that they hope to attain eternal felicity by the frequent invocation of his name. One of the figures of this idol is repreſented at Rome.

Amida (anc. geog.), a principal city of Meſopotamia (Liber Notitiæ); *Ammæa* (Ptolemy); ſituated on a high mountain, on the borders of Aſſyria, on the Tigris, where it receives the Nymphius.—It was taken from the Romans, in the time of the emperor Conſtans, by Sapores king of Perſia. The ſiege is ſaid to have coſt him 30,000 men; however, he reduced it to ſuch ruin, that the emperor afterwards wept over it. According to Ammianus Marcellinus, the city was raſed; the chief officers were crucified; and the reſt, with the ſoldiers and inhabitants, either put to the ſword or carried into captivity, except our hiſtorian himſelf, and two or three more, who, in the dead of the night, eſcaped through a poſtern unperceived by the enemy. The inhabitants of Niſibis, however, being obliged to leave their own city by Jovian's treaty with

Figure 1: *
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